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# *Thomas Hobbes on Human Nature*

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Thomas Hobbes's *Leviathan* (1651), second only perhaps to Niccolo Machiavelli's *The Prince* (1532), is considered one of modern Europe's greatest political treatises. Among Hobbes's writings on law, moral philosophy, physics, optics, and geometry are *A Briefe of the Art of Rhetorique* (1637) and the tripartite corpus of *De cive* (1647), *De corpore* (1655), and *De homine* (1658). Still, *Leviathan* remains of singular importance in modern political theory as well as for the purpose of this short critical essay. Hobbes is most famous or infamous for the doctrines of the sovereign and the social contract as articulated in *Leviathan.* However, this essay focuses on the state-of-nature doctrine, which Hobbes also called the "natural condition," and the manner in which it is deployed to signify people of color. This chapter also takes account of the internalizing effects of this doctrine by people of color. I am interested, albeit in a cursory manner, in the ways people of color often internalize the representational force of stereotypes that circumscribe human beings within the state of nature. Toward the end of this chapter, I will take as an example the contemporary rap group Young Money. The natural condition marks out a space of primitive, irrational, and animal existence that must necessarily be restrained by the *civitas* (civil society, city-state) for the procurement of peace. To critically understand the natural-condition doctrine, I first situate it within Hobbes's own seventeenth-century world. Second, I briefly discuss the anthropological and social aspects of the natural condition and its relationship to the *civitas.* After this, I discuss its significance for the production of the Other, beyond the pale of civil society.

# ***HOBBES AND THE NEW SCIENCE***

The son of a minor clergyman in England, the legendary English philosopher Thomas Hobbes had humble beginnings. Born in1588, he was educated at Oxford and was well acquainted with Anglican politics. I will soon indicate the significance of this connection. His was a time of great political and philosophical upheaval, precipitated by various Renaissance and Reformation movements that circulated throughout early modern Europe. These movements were nothing short of a hermeneutical revolution that destabilized traditional social and political structures of Christendom and medieval scholastic theology. In seventeenth-century England, scientific questioning of these authorities produced such conflicts, forcing Hobbes to flee for Paris in 1640. During the next decade, as an ex-patriot of a land now raging with civil war, Hobbes penned his magnum opus, *Leviathan*. Characterized by rising death tolls, extensive property damage, an unstable economy, and uneasy alliances, England declined into barbarism and violence. The English Civil War (1641–51) capped nearly a century of such conflicts and served to further the impetus for Hobbes's work.

For Hobbes, religious opinion, based on tradition and authority, was the force behind the political conflicts and must not serve as justification for political authority. In England, Protestants deployed natural law theory, in which everything is governed by universal and necessary laws, to argue for the political right of Calvinist members of Parliament to resist nominalist Anglicans, who supported the crown's supremacy by divine right. This clash resulted in a "war of all against all," a phrase repeated in Hobbes's doctrine of the natural condition. Hobbes tries to mediate these warring parties by justifying civil power on scientific grounds rather than religious ones. In turn, this would move political discourse away from the

antagonisms between competing religious factions. Unlike traditional religious authorities, scientifically grounded civil power is endowed with unprecedented unity, permanency, and authority. Following Bacon's experimental theory that science is for the amelioration of the human condition, Hobbes's political science was in the service of ameliorating the conditions that brought England into civil war.[1]

The "new science," Baconian empiricism, was thought to be more reliable than religious authority alone. It played a critical role in Hobbes's understanding and interpretation of the social and political world. Science discloses a previously inconceivable natural world, the harmonious diversity of which is orchestrated by natural law. Hobbes refers to nature as a work of art, indeed, "the Art whereby God hath made and governes the World."[2] The new science also offers a method for measuring the highest level of probability in knowledge claims—not only what can be known but also what is known. Bacon's method aimed at mastery over nature through three critical moves. First is the gathering of data from senses and observation. Second is a move from induction to generalizations or abstractions. The third move involves testing generalized conclusions or abstractions by the observations of others, as a critical check against error. Hobbes's approach to politics incorporated these steps, and he was convinced that the findings he collected from available resources at the time provided him with more than enough evidence to draw conclusive judgments about the natural condition of humankind as a primitive in relation to advanced civil society. The natural condition, then, is one of Hobbes's critical abstractions from empirical research in his scientific practice.

Hobbes relates this abstraction to politics in order to create a political science that discerns the formal causes of human conflicts and to formulate general and immutable laws that make for a science of politics, whose end is perpetual peace. Such a political science is inspired

by Hobbes's understanding of nature as a divine art. The art of nature orders diversity by directing every natural body toward its proper end. *Leviathan* deploys the methods of the natural sciences to enable political mastery over human action in the same way that the sciences enable mastery over other natural bodies. The art by which God has made and governs the world is imitated in the human construction of *Leviathan*, the *civitas* that harmoniously orders and balances diverse human interests.[3] Hobbes was persuaded that the science of politics could simultaneously procure objective rational interests necessary for life, health, and security and produce the conditions necessary for the flourishing of subjective interests by first discerning natural law. The first precept of natural law is to "seek peace, and follow it," and Hobbes conceives of the *civitas* as orchestrating human interests in pursuit of this precept.[4] However, the natural condition exists as the barrier to lasting peace within the *civitas*.

## THE NATURAL CONDITION

Recently colonized North America was critical to Hobbes's political science. Reports of so-called new-world savages influenced his empirical lens as he theorized the natural human condition. The distinctive mark of the natural condition is irrationality. Much like the sundry aspects of nature disclosed by the sciences of Hobbes's day, the natural condition is also marked by difference in passion, thought, opinion, and doctrine. In this state, few give reasoned attention to consequences of their actions. All are by nature equal, and each possesses the liberty or natural right to use one's natural strength and intellect to get about in the world and pursue irrational ends by any means deemed fit. Hobbes says:

> The Right of Nature . . . is the Liberty each man hath, to use his own power, as he will himself, for the preservation of his own Nature; that is to say, of his own Life; and consequently, of doing any

> thing, which in his own Judgement, and Reason, he shall conceive to be the aptest means thereunto.[5]

In the natural condition, human beings possess the natural right to anything and are limited only by natural impediments. Good, evil, vice, and virtue are subjectively defined so that a diversity of goods flourishes. Yet, in distinction from nature, the divine art that harmonizes the world, no mechanism exists in the natural condition that harmoniously governs so wide a range of differences.

As a result of irrational human acts oriented toward the attainment of a diversity of goods, ironically, the natural condition is inclined toward war. It is characterized by primitivism, barbaric passions, and antagonistic relationality. While natural liberty inspires hope for desired ends, competition foils such hopes, and diffidence with respect to goods ascribed to individuals results in war of all against all. Life is plagued by the domination of unchecked power, violence, insecurity, and perpetual war. There is little regard for the natural right or the bodies of others, and life is "solitary, poore, nasty, brutish, and short."[6] Hobbes says:

> The condition of Man . . . is a condition of Warre of every one against every one. . . . It followeth, that in such a condition, every man has a right to every thing; even to one anothers body. And therefore, as long as this natural Right of every man to every thing endureth, there can be no security to any man . . . of living out the time, which Nature ordinarily alloweth men to live.[7]

In a tragic paradox, the exercise of natural right, in the natural condition, is impossible. Unimpeded irrational action is slave to unrestrained appetites and incalculable destruction. Rational interests cannot be secured. Indeed, for Hobbes, this was the case in ungoverned North America, where there reside "savage people in many places, . . . [the] concord whereof dependeth on naturall lust, . . . and [they] live at this day in that brutish manner."[8]

The inevitable violent consequences of the natural condition demonstrate the necessity of the *civitas*, or civil society. In the natural condition, human beings reckon that the preservation of objective interests requires a social contract by which the political community is instituted. The

*civitas* preserves the objective interests of citizens by producing or fostering a particular set of relations completely at odds with those in the natural condition. In turn, these relations procure certain ends, such as the good life, the good person, the well-ordered city, or peace. Hobbes's scientific politics procures peace by harmoniously negotiating the interests of all by an overarching rational interest, much as God's art makes and governs the world. In the natural condition beyond the political community, humans enjoy an animal existence in the crudest sense of the words. They are untamed, beastly, and barbaric. From this condition, it follows that social arrangements are disorganized, weak, frequently dysfunctional, and incapable of securing rational interests. Unlike the natural condition, civil society is well-ordered, united, secure, and prosperous. The uncivilized amount to nothing more than brutes, but within the *civitas*, people live qualitatively better lives and become qualitatively better humans. Since the *civitas* is predicated on objective rational interests, Hobbes declares that the head of the *civitas* possesses the power and authority of a "Mortall God."[9] Subjects' sole loyalty is to the head, who alone implements customs and laws. War and peace, judicature and censorship, even right and wrong—all become the prerogative of the sovereign head for the preservation of *Leviathan*.

## THE NATURAL CONDITION AND THE PRODUCTION OF THE OTHER

In the absence of viable religious justification of political authority, Hobbes turns to the Baconian empirical method to argue that civil society is necessary for achieving life, health, security, and peace. However, what I call the "natural condition" is an abstraction and not an empirically accurate description of newly encountered societies of Others in the New World. In the following pages, I briefly consider both how this abstraction, having become a stereotype, is

internalized by certain Others even today, and how this stereotype still functions to justify the authority of contemporary Leviathans.

The natural condition is irrational, lustful, warring, and premoral. It reduces human beings to essential characteristics and portrays them by a fixed nature. This representational practice of stereotyping is harmful to the production of the Other, and in Hobbes's case, to Native Americans. As a stereotype, the natural condition marks the Other in distinctive ways. First, polarized binaries within the natural condition make it easier to fix its meaning. Although meaning can never be fixed in the truest sense of the word, meaning nevertheless becomes fixed disjunctively as either/or. The natural condition becomes either a place of absolute freedom (natural right) or absolute nonfreedom (a war of all against all), either a state of utter irrationality or a social contract. Second, the natural condition contains a sexual element. As Hobbes puts it, "Concord whereof depends on natural lust." Destructive sexual passions risk the order of civilization. Third, the natural condition is characterized as brutish and childishly irrational, thus emphasizing bodily strength over intellectual capabilities.

In *Leviathan*, we find a representational practice that was not only critical in the production of the Other in Hobbes's times, but also appears internalized in practices signifying the Other in our own times. This is especially true in the U.S. context, where, within broad regimes of representations, African Americans are confined to particular abstractions that echo the natural condition by drawing on one or more of its distinctive marks described above. To show how the internalization of the natural condition works, I focus on one instance: the popular rap group Young Money, formed by the world-renowned rapper and musician Lil Wayne (2009). Here, rap is all too often the straw man and scapegoat for cultural criticism, precisely insofar as it internalizes the Hobbesian natural condition. The genre's unprecedented global appeal forces

upon it the "burden of representation," in which rap represents all Black art and consequently all Black people. As a result of this representational burden, rap is expected to show communal, racial, or moral responsibility. It is not my intention to place this unfair burden on rap's shoulders. Rather, my claim is that rap frequently represents African Americans in ways that demonstrate an internalization and presentation of stereotypes found in *Leviathan*'s category of "natural condition." Furthermore, these stereotypes function much in the same manner and for the same purposes as they did in Hobbes' day, namely as legitimating conditions for coercive civil authorities.

I suggest that the natural condition theorized in the seventeenth century is echoed in the twenty-first century's Young Money in at least three ways. First, there are the binaries attributed to the group. As in the natural condition, the group is usually portrayed as lawless, while bound by some natural law or code. Another binary is present in the portrayal of group members as being both admirably honest (childlike), transparent, and gifted, and at the same time, coldhearted, murderous animals. These binaries create an either/or paradigm, and it becomes easier to fix a meaning to Young Money. They are either extremely honest or murderers, and there exists no possibility outside these meanings. Second, Young Money displays a strong barbaric sexual element. Examples abound, but perhaps the most blatant are Lil Wayne's lyrical suggestions that he has literally transformed into a penis. One could also point beyond lyrics to names of members such as "Nikki Minaj." Finally, in self-identifying as "crazy," "goblins," and even "Louisi-animals," Young Money portrays itself as a band of irrational and uncivilized brutes given to animalistic instincts. These traits point to an internalization of *Leviathan*'s natural condition by Young Money.

Meaning can never be permanently fixed. Nor can it be reduced to a single interpretation. However, within the regime of representations in the Western world, the meaning of *Young Money* becomes settled when viewed within a nature/culture dialectic. Representing the natural condition, *Young Money* stands as the primitive underside to modern Western cultural conceptions of acceptability and normalcy. Such conceptions, found in Hobbes's writings, include cultural values such as self-control, responsibility, refinement, and belief in reason. These cultural values have often been depicted as essential to personal fulfillment and social flourishing. As irrational, sex-crazed, violent animals, Young Money is without culture, thus subhuman; underdeveloped at best. Young Money becomes representative of both individual instances of nihilism and the decline or complete absence of acceptable social relations. Moreover, when interpreted within a history of representations that privileges a meaning of African Americans as irrational, sexually barbaric, and childish, Young Money contributes to centuries-long processes of "naturing" the Other. The Other is "natured" when aspects of Others are represented so consistently that they are believed to be permanently fixed and natural, rather than culturally produced.

Agency, and even freedom, can be found in internalizing stereotypes. And certainly internalization is not an entirely passive phenomenon. These internalizations and reproductions, then, are not intrinsically problematic. For me, one of the most lamentable consequences of internalizing "natured" Others is the civil response has not changed much from Hobbes' day to our own. Just as the *civitas* delivered humankind from the natural condition then, the great *Leviathan* still operates with similar authority, power, and agenda in contemporary times. For the Others who stand in as representatives for nature—who for purposes of this essay are mostly African Americans in the U.S. context—the results have been disastrous. These populations have

been most exposed to the disciplinary and violent power of the *civitas* and thus suffer economic, educational, and health hardships. These populations are also most likely to be treated nihilistically by the policing power of civil society, contributing to frighteningly disparate proportions of African Americans in correctional facilities, jails, and prisons. In the early twenty-first century, the American *civitas*'s remedy for nature is restraint and rapine at the hands of the Mortal God.

To conclude, just as the "state of nature" or the "natural condition" displays warring interests, which can be remedied only by the authority of the *civitas* in Hobbes's *Leviathan*, so "natured" Others are dealt with by the authority of sovereign civil power today. Within the Anglo-American spheres of civil powers, in both the British and American Leviathans, Native and African Americans historically have borne the burden of representing nature's Others. With the global circulation of Leviathan empires from the West, the burden of representing the state of nature—the abstraction of historical human conditions in the scientization of the Other—extends well into our present historical horizon on a global scale. There it marks off people of color around the world by stereotypes and fetishisms, and by brute, irrational, and unmitigated natures. They fall beyond the pale of civil society, which renders them ready subjects of Leviathan's coercive sovereign power. Hobbes's scientific practices remind us that abstractions are essential to the productions of knowledge, whether of human beings as a species or as groups. They are also important for the manner in which they circulate throughout signifying systems, including sociopolitical regimes. However, Hobbes's *Leviathan* also discloses the ways in which abstractions can be dangerously oriented toward totality, replicating themselves into culturally debilitating stereotypes, which having become "natural," overdetermine people of color by the permanent fixture of an unmediated natural condition.

## Notes

[1]. Thomas Hobbes, *Leviathan*, ed. Richard Tuck (New York: Cambridge University Press, 2006), 3.

[2]. Ibid., 9.

[3]. Ibid.

[4]. Ibid., 91–92.

[5]. Ibid., 91.

[6]. Ibid., 89.

[7]. Ibid., 91.

[8]. Ibid., 89.

[9]. Ibid., 120.